

of access to ice.

India currently has just two Olympic-size artificial ice rinks — the NDS Stadium in Leh and the Himadri Ice Rink in Dehradun. While Ladakh can still depend on natural ice, athletes from states such as Maharashtra, Tamil Nadu, Karnataka or Haryana have no such advantage, relying entirely on limited artificial facilities.

"An ice rink is highly specialised infrastructure," Amitabh explains. "You cannot have it at every district or even state level. It has to be a progressive process." For now, that progression comes at a steep price. Renting ice can cost between ₹10,000 and ₹15,000 per hour — a figure that turns daily training into both a logistical and financial puzzle, especially for young athletes still finding their feet in the sport.

"Earlier, the problem was lack of infrastructure. Now the infrastructure exists, but it is not accessible," says Noyal C. Cherian, a speed skater from Madhya Pradesh who has represented India at the Asian Winter Games. Training at Dehradun, he adds, often requires pooling athletes merely to split costs, followed by navigating layers of permissions. "What is the point of building such an excellent rink if it is so difficult for athletes to use it?"

Amitabh frames the issue through the lens of scarcity rather than bureaucracy. "There is no red tape — that is not the correct terminology," he says. "Accessibility is low because we only have two Olympic-size rinks." Each rink can be used for roughly 12 hours a day, time that must be divided between short-track speed skating, figure skating and ice hockey — three disciplines competing for the same frozen surface. "If four hours are given to hockey, the same has to be given to figure skating and speed skating. That's where the constraint comes in."

Cost, he concedes, is unavoidable. "Ice, all over the world, is expensive. Infrastructure cost is one part; maintenance is another. This is not like renting a badminton court for ₹200." Even abroad, Amitabh notes, ice time can cost close to \$300 an hour (1\$ = approximately ₹90.58) — a reality that continues to push many Indian skaters overseas in search of consistent access and higher-quality competition.

That migration is already visible. Hyderabad's Nayana Sri Talluri (left), who won two gold medals at KIWG 2026, has moved to the University of Calgary in Canada. Like many Indian ice athletes, she finances her career herself — a common thread in a sport that has struggled to attract sustained sponsorship. With ice skating still viewed as niche and commercially uncertain, corporate backing remains limited, forcing families to shoulder costs that quickly escalate.

"Ice sports require specialised equipment," Amitabh adds. "Blades are expensive, ice time is expensive. Nowhere in the world is ice free." Until athletes reach a level where sponsorship becomes viable, the burden of investment remains front-loaded — often determining who continues and who is forced to step away,

regardless of talent.

For Jay Yadav, Haryana's gold medallist in the men's short-track relay, the sacrifice is more local but no less demanding. He travels 60 kilometres daily from Rewari to Gurugram to train at the Ambience Mall rink — smaller than regulation size, but the only option available. "I love what I do, so the travel doesn't bother me," he says. "But more government support is definitely needed."

That call is echoed across camps. Athletes argue that while sponsorship ecosystems take time to mature, targeted government intervention could provide immediate relief — whether through subsidised ice time, regional training hubs or public-private partnerships to build smaller rinks. Amitabh maintains that progress is underway. "The infrastructure problem that existed earlier is now being addressed," he says, expressing hope that more rinks will come up in the coming years. He acknowledges, however, that accessibility will never be universal. "We are a big country. The rate of creating rinks compared to population growth will always be mismatched. The challenge is to balance quality with quantity."

In the interim, stopgap solutions may help bridge the gap. Karan Rai, director at iSkate and manager of the Gurugram rink, believes smaller, makeshift ice rinks can be set up within 12 hours using the right equipment. He aims to expand into western and southern India — regions that have witnessed a sharp rise in interest despite limited facilities — offering athletes at least a functional pathway into the sport.

For the ISAI, the focus remains firmly performance-driven. "We aim to be on the world stage," Amitabh says. The federation has rolled out development programmes, hosted camps with international coaches and judges, and identified clear milestones — the 2028 Youth Olympics, the 2029 Asian Winter Games and the 2030 Winter Olympics. These targets, Amitabh believes, provide direction to a sport still finding its identity within India's broader sporting ecosystem.

Given all the limitations, athletes remain unanimous about one thing: the importance of the Khelo India Winter Games. For many, it is the only competition where cost does not dictate participation. All expenses — flights, accommodation and logistics — are borne by the Sports Authority of India, offering a rare level playing field in an otherwise expensive sport.

In the 2026 edition, old assumptions fractured, new states emerged, new champions rose, and long-standing challenges resurfaced. The medals point to a future filled with possibilities. Whether that promise translates into sustained global relevance will depend on how seriously governments, sponsors and sporting bodies choose to invest once the ice melts and the spotlight fades.

The writer was at the event on invitation by Sports Authority of India.